

India

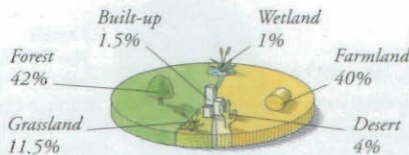
 With more than 450 million voters, India is the world's largest democracy. In 1947, the country became independent of Britain, and was left with a vast rail network, international ports, and working farms and factories, all of which have contributed to its industrial success. Today, India has many industries and large modern cities, although millions of people still live in extreme poverty. India has rich mineral resources, including oil, iron, bauxite, coal, and manganese.

People

Most Indians live according to the caste system, which indicates their role in society, who they can marry, and the work they can do. However, the caste system is now more flexible than in the past. Women have equal rights by law, but rarely in practice. Several measures to reduce India's rising population have been initiated by the state, but have remained largely unsuccessful.



Indian family



Land use

Most of India's farmland is used for growing fruit and cereals, and the country is largely self-sufficient in food. With such a large population to feed, demand for farmland is high, and many Indian forests have been felled to make way for crops. Some of the land is used for mining.

Films are often packed with stars, dancing, action, and romance.



Film-making

India has a highly successful film industry and makes more films than any other country including the USA. The centre of the film industry is "Bollywood" – India's Hollywood – in Bombay.

Music

India has a long and varied musical tradition. There are two classical forms of music: *Hindustani* and *Carnatic*. Both are based on the *raga*, a mixture of melody and scales.

Typical classical instruments include the *sitar* and the *sarod* (which are both lutes), flutes, drums, and the European violin. Folk music varies from region to region and is played on at least 500 different kinds of instruments.



Sitar

INDIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY New Delhi

AREA 3,973,190 sq km
(1,147,949 sq miles)

POPULATION 1,000,000,000

MAIN LANGUAGES Hindi, English

MAJOR RELIGIONS Hindu, Muslim

CURRENCY Rupee

LIFE EXPECTANCY 63 years

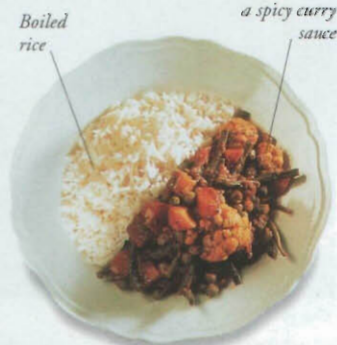
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR 2,500

GOVERNMENT Multi-party democracy

ADULT LITERACY 57%

Food

The traditional Indian food is curry, a sauce flavoured with a subtle blend of spices, such as turmeric, cardamom, ginger, coriander, nutmeg, and poppy seed, eaten with meat or vegetables. Meat dishes, mainly lamb and chicken, are savoured in the north. In southern India, vegetables and pulses such as *dhal* (lentils), coconut, and fresh sea food are enjoyed with curry. Rice and unleavened breads, such as *chapatis*, *parathas*, and *poori*, are eaten with meals.



New Delhi

Purpose-built by the British as India's capital, New Delhi has a population of 301,000 and lies 5 km (3 miles) from the old city of Delhi, with 16,000,000 people. Compared with Delhi's winding streets, temples, mosques, and bazaars, New Delhi has tree-lined boulevards and spacious parks.



Jama Masjid, Delhi

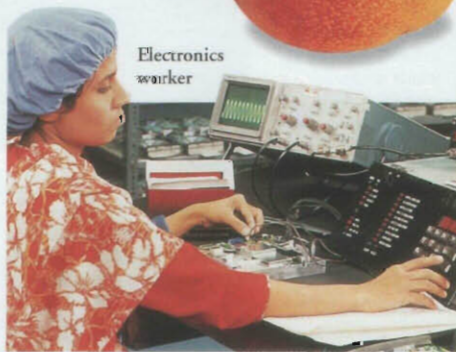
Farming

About two-thirds of Indians are involved in agriculture. Many are poor farmers who grow just enough food to feed their families. Others work on plantations producing cash crops, such as tea, rubber, coffee, sugar, bananas, mangoes, cotton, and tobacco. India exports timber, including teak, sandalwood, and rosewood. Cattle are reared for butter and ghee, but not for beef, forbidden by the Hindu religion.



Industry

The country's economy is still based on small, cottage industries. But, aided by a large, cheap work-force, India's industry is growing rapidly. In the south, Bangalore is now a centre for electronics, and many international companies have factories there. India also exports machinery, cut diamonds, textiles, clothing, and chemicals.



Electronics worker

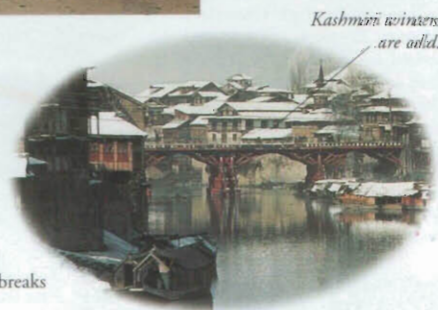


Transport

Railways in India total 62,810 km (39,030 miles). Every year they carry two-thirds of all freight and three billion passengers. India has 2,160,000 km (1,342,000 miles) of roads, only half of which are paved. Only one person in 300 owns a car, but buses are widely used and very crowded. In rural areas, ox carts are common, and in cities, people ride bicycles, scooters, or travel by taxi and rickshaws.

Kashmir

In 1947, Pakistan and India separated. Since then, they have disputed ownership of the former princely state of Kashmir. Part of Kashmir lies in the Indian state of Jammu and Kashmir. The rest is ruled by Pakistan, which claims it all because most of the people who live there are Muslims. Fighting breaks out from time to time.



Kashmiri winters are cold.